
UNIT 6 WORLD WAR II: CAUSES AND CONSEQUENCES*

Structure

- 6.0 Objectives
- 6.1 Introduction
- 6.2 Causes and Outbreak of World War II
 - 6.2.1 The War Begins
 - 6.2.2 USA and USSR become Allies
- 6.3 Defeat of the Axis Powers
 - 6.3.1 Defeat of Italy and Germany
 - 6.3.2 Defeat of Japan
- 6.4 Peacemaking after the Second World War
 - 6.4.1 The Potsdam Conference
 - 6.4.2 Treaties of Peace
- 6.5 India's Contribution to the Second World War
- 6.6 Emergence of Super Powers
 - 6.6.1 The United States became a Nuclear Power
 - 6.6.2 Soviet Union's Challenge to the United States
- 6.7 Let Us Sum Up
- 6.8 References
- 6.9 Answers to Check Your Progress Exercises

6.0 OBJECTIVES

In this Unit, you will be reading about World War II that started in September 1939 and ended only in August 1945. By going through this Unit, you should be able to:

- Explain the causes for the outbreak of World War II
- Describe how the USA and USSR became allies
- Discuss the outcome of the war and peace treaties signed at the end of the war, and
- Describe the rise of USA and USSR as two superpowers.

6.1 INTRODUCTION

World War II began in 1939 with German aggression on Poland on 1st September. Earlier, two erstwhile enemies namely Germany and the Soviet Union had signed a non-aggression pact making way for Polish partition between two of them. All efforts to reach an understanding between the Soviet Union on the one hand and Britain and France on the other hand proved fruitless. International Relations were still characterized by the same evil practices that had led to the outbreak of the First World War – aggression for territorial expansion and secret pacts among European great powers. In fact, secret negotiations were being simultaneously

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carried on between the Soviet Union and Germany and between Britain and Germany. Britain and France took the Soviet Union for granted and did not bother to conclude a military alliance with the latter. This paved the way for Soviet-German non-aggression pact and the German attack on Poland.

A few months before the outbreak of World War II, both Britain and France had given guarantees to Poland assuring that in case of aggression on it, they would provide her with all possible assistance. When all attempts to avoid war and protecting Poland had failed, Britain and France declared war on Germany on September 3, 1939. Italy remained neutral in the war for some time but finally joined the war on the side of Germany in June 1940. After Germany had won decisive victories against several countries in Europe, it waged a war against the Soviet Union also on June 22, 1941. This brought USSR into the Allied Camp. With the Japanese bombardment of Pearl Harbour on December 7, 1941, the United States finally entered the war. The war was fought between the Allies (Britain, France, Soviet Union, USA and their friends) on the one side and the Axis Powers (Germany, Italy and Japan) on the other. The War ended in the unconditional surrender of Italy, Germany and Japan in that order.

6.2 CAUSES AND OUTBREAK OF WORLD WAR II

You have read about World War II that broke out in September 1939 after the German attack on Poland, and consequent declaration of war by Britain and France against Germany. This gives the impression that the war was caused by the Polish dispute. This is partly true. Polish problem was indeed the immediate cause of the war, but many other reasons created the situation in which war became unavoidable. Let us briefly discuss all the distant as well as immediate causes of the War.

Treaty of Versailles: An attempt was made in Paris Peace Conference, held after the First World War, in 1919 to establish an ideal world order based on justice, peace and disarmament. But what finally emerged in the shape of Treaty of Versailles was a dictated treaty of peace imposed upon Germany. The victorious participants lacked sincerity of purpose.

The Paris Peace Conference lasted five months and was dominated by the ‘four big’ victorious powers (Britain, France, Italy and the US). None of the defeated powers were part of the peace process. Even smaller countries who had fought on the side of Allies were left out. Normal courtesies expected by the representatives of a sovereign country were not extended to Germany. The Treaty of Peace was drafted by Allies without any negotiations with defeated Germany. On May 7, 1919, Germany was given the draft treaty for its suggestion to be given in writing within three weeks. The announcement of terms of the treaty resulted in a fierce outburst of resentment in Germany. Germany denied that it alone was responsible for the war. Germany raised many objections and suggested modifications but, except for one modification, all the objections were brushed aside. Finally, Germany was made to sign the Treaty of Versailles on June 28, 1919. Germans called it a “diktat”, and could not bear this insult and humiliation. The Allies also signed separate treaties with Austria, Bulgaria, Hungary and Turkey. The formal peacemaking process wasn’t concluded until the signing of the Treaty of Lausanne in July 1923.

Treaty of Versailles was a punishing treaty imposed on Germany (i) Article 231 held Germany guilty of war crimes. (ii) It was forced to give up territory to Belgium, Czechoslovakia and Poland, return Alsace and Lorraine to France and cede all of its overseas colonies in China, Pacific and Africa to the Allied nations. (iii) Germany was asked to drastically reduce its armed forces, and not to have its air force. It was made to accept the demilitarization and Allied occupation of the region around the Rhine River. (iv) The Versailles Treaty redrew the borders of Europe. It created an increasingly unstable collection of smaller nations by carving up the former Austro-Hungarian Empire into states like Yugoslavia, Poland and Czechoslovakia. Of the Ottoman Empire, only the Turkish heartland was left intact; its remaining European peripheries were undone and Middle Eastern provinces were carved as European 'Mandate' under the League of Nations. Europeans powers still practised balance of powers; now keeping a balance of power became more unstable with so many small states. (v) Germany was asked to pay several billion in reparations for causing "civilian damages". The total reparations: "About 269 bn gold marks, to be exact – the equivalent of around 100,000 tonnes of gold" (BBC: October 2, 2010).

France and Britain were largely responsible for the punitive treaty and the unstable peace that ensued in Europe. France had wanted to disarm Germany, clip its military capability, humiliate it, and take revenge for all its past defeats at the hands of Germany. War had given Britain an opportunity to dominate Europe and remake it. It did not want to lose its domination over Europe; and looked at the US and President Wilson's 14-Point programme with suspicion.

British economist John Maynard Keynes had found that Germany could not possibly pay so much in reparations without severe risks to the entire European economy. US President Herbert Hoover blamed reparations for causing the Great Depression of 1929. Many realized that Germany could not pay all the reparations. The 1924 Dawes Plan and the 1929 Young Plan reduced the debt to 112 billion gold marks; Germany was granted loans to meet its payment schedule. The 1929 world depression sent all European economies into a long tailspin. The US then proposed a one-year moratorium on German payments. Germany had paid only about one-eighth of what it owed when Hitler came to power and refused to pay any more of the reparations. The act of defiance greatly appealed to the nationalist pride of Germans. The European Allied powers, however, won't give up. After the Second World War, Germany was divided into states – the capitalist Federal Republic of Germany (FRG) and the socialist German Democratic Republic (GDR). Who was the successor state that would now pay the reparations? The 1953 London Treaty agreed to suspend the payment of reparations till the two Germanys united. The question of debt recovery arose in 1990 with German reunification. It was then agreed that in the altered international circumstances, payment of reparations should be written off once and for all. However, it was only in 2010 that Germany made the final payment of 70 million Euros to pay the interest on loans it had taken to pay the reparations.

The Treaty of Versailles mutilated and humiliated Germany. Twenty years later, it was the turn of Germany to take revenge. Hitler had come on the centre stage, led his proud people to avenge their humiliation and thus paved the way for the Second World War.

Failure of Collective Security System: Collective security system was a noteworthy ideal the world leaders had pledged at the end of the First World

War. Providing security collectively to the victim of international aggression was its aim. The Covenant of the League of Nations provided that in case of aggression, members of the League, by their collective action, would compel the aggressor to withdraw. This collective action could either be in the form of economic sanctions against the aggressor, or military support to the victim of aggression or both.

During the inter-war years, it was, however, proved that the League was an ineffective organisation in respect of a big power if the latter decided to wage a war against, or annexe, a small country. In 1931, Japan committed aggression against China and by early 1932, managed to conquer Manchuria – a province of China. Japan very cleverly kept on telling the League that her action in Manchuria was in self-defence i.e. (protecting life and property of Japanese in Manchuria, and only a police action not aggression). Japan, a permanent member of the League, forged ahead to establish a puppet Manchukuo regime in Manchuria. When the League asked member-nations not to recognise Manchukuo, Japan left the League but retained control on the conquered territory.

Later, in 1935 Italy waged a war against Abyssinia and in May 1936 formally annexed that country into Italian Empire. The League tried to enforce collective security system, declared Italy an aggressor and clamped economic sanctions. All this was of no avail as no military action was taken against Italy who was also a big power and permanent member of the League Council. Similarly, no action was taken by a weak League of Nations against Germany. When she repudiated the military clauses of the Versailles Treaty (1919) and the freely negotiated Locarno pact, remilitarized Rhineland (1936), annexed Austria (1938) and dismembered Czechoslovakia (1938-39). Thus, failure of the collective security system turned out to be a major cause of World War II.

Failure of Disarmament: It was agreed at the Paris Peace Conference that world peace could be ensured only if nations reduced their armaments to a point consistent with their domestic safety or defence. That means all the weapons of offensive nature were to be destroyed. The task of preparing a plan for the reduction of armaments was entrusted to the League of Nations. The League appointed temporary Mixed Commission in 1920 which however could not do any substantial work because France insisted on security before this disarmament. In 1925 Preparatory Commission was instituted. Due to divergent views of nations that mattered, it could not identify offensive weapons. Finally, without much preparatory work, a Disarmament Conference met at Geneva in February 1932. Once again mutual distrust and suspicion led to the failure of the Conference, after protracted negotiations.

Germany had been disarmed by the Treaty of Versailles. Victor nations were to disarm later. They, however, never really wanted to disarm. Therefore, in October 1933 Germany declared that she was leaving both the Disarmament Conference and the League of Nations. Later in 1935 Germany formally declared that she was no more bound by the military or disarmament clauses of the Treaty of Versailles. Other countries were already in possession of large quantities of armaments and big armed forces. German decision heralded a massive armament race which led to an armed conflict. The failure of disarmament became yet another major cause of Second World War.

World Economic Crisis: World economic crisis began in 1929 with sudden stoppage of loans by the American financial houses to the European countries. Many of them, particularly Germany, were making rapid industrial progress mostly with the borrowed American money. The economic crisis had its severe impact during 1930-32. It adversely affected the economics of most countries either directly or indirectly. Germany proved to be the worst affected country where nearly 700,000 people were rendered jobless. It was forced to declare that it would not make any more payment of reparations. Out of the economic crisis of Germany emerged Nazi dictatorship of Adolf Hitler. He became Chancellor of Germany in 1933, but soon destroyed democracy and established his dictatorship. Meanwhile, even England had to take some harsh measures like abandoning the gold standard. Germany, Japan and Italy took advantage of this economic crisis and separately embarked upon aggressive designs. They set up their Fascist Bloc which became largely responsible for the Second World War.

Rome-Berlin-Tokyo Axis: On the eve of the First World War, Europe was divided into two hostile camps. The same process was once again repeated with the formation of an alliance of Germany, Japan and Italy. It was concluded through the Anti-Comintern pact during 1936-37. This combination of Fascist powers generally called the Rome-Berlin-Tokyo Axis was aimed at imperialist expansion. They glorified war, and openly denounced peaceful settlement of disputes. They bullied Western countries and victimised weaker nations like China, Austria, Czechoslovakia, Albania and Poland. Their war-like acts and aggression though noticed, yet went unpunished. Alarmed at the conduct of Axis powers, England and France came closer to each other and an unsuccessful attempt was made at the formation of an Anglo-French-Soviet Front. Although France and the Soviet Union had an alliance, yet in their desire to appease Hitler, France and England ignored the Soviet Union and when Stalin wanted a military pact between three non-Fascist powers they took it easy. The Soviet Union became suspicious and surprised the world by signing the non-aggression pact with Germany. This directly cleared the way for the German attack on Poland which led to the outbreak of the Second World War. While the Soviet Union also invaded Poland, England and France declared war on Germany.

The Problem of National Minorities: Peace settlement after the First World War had resulted in the formation of new nation-states in Europe, with large national minorities left behind uncared for. President Woodrow Wilson of the United States had advocated the principle of self-determination. But on account of various strategic considerations, this principle was never properly implemented. Thus, for example, large German minorities found themselves in the company of non-Germans in Poland and Czechoslovakia. There were Russian minorities in Poland and Rumania; and even after the Minority Treaties were concluded after the Paris conference, about 750,000 Germans were under foreign rule. Hitler exploited the situation and in the name of denial of rights to German minorities in Czechoslovakia and Poland prepared to attack these countries. He annexed Austria, destroyed and dismembered Czechoslovakia and finally invaded Poland. Thus, the problem of minorities became an important issue and major excuse for the war.

Appeasement by Britain and France: Foreign policy based on appeasement of Nazi-Fascist dictators turned out to be a major cause of the Second World War. After the First World War, there appeared a rift in the policies of Britain and

France. Balance of power had always been the cornerstone of the British foreign policy. Britain feared that a very powerful France would disturb the balance of power in Europe. Hence, it helped Germany against France in the inter-war years. Once Hitler came to power in Germany and Italy became an ally of the Nazi dictator, Britain quickly moved closer to France who badly needed British assistance against a very hostile Germany. After 1933, France's foreign policy virtually became an extension of British foreign policy. Britain was worried about the growing influence of Communism. Not only the Soviet Union had to be effectively challenged, but the so-called popular fronts in France and Spain had also to be destroyed. With this objective in view, Britain adopted the policy of appeasement towards Hitler and Mussolini. France soon followed suit. Appeasement was started by Prime Minister Stanley Baldwin but vigorously pursued by Neville Chamberlain in 1938. Anglo-French desire to help Mussolini during the Abyssinian War, while maintaining support for League efforts, their virtual surrender to Hitler at the Munich Conference, and their inability to protect weaker nations like Austria and Albania were clear evidence of Anglo-French weakness and this prepared the ground for the War.

German Attack on Poland: The apparent and immediate cause of the war was the German attack on Poland on September 1, 1939. Earlier, when all attempts at an Anglo-French alliance with the Soviet Union had failed, Hitler entered a non-aggression pact with Stalin. This was most unexpected, as, for several years, only hatred had existed between Nazi Germany and Soviet Russia. Now, keen to partition off Poland between themselves, Germany and the Soviet Union signed the pact not to wage war against each other. Yet, as events turned out, the pact was called by its critics as "simple aggression pact against Poland". In a secret pact, which emerged only in 1945, the two countries had resolved to divide Eastern Europe into their spheres on September 1, 1939, England and France had already assured Poland of their help in case of an invasion. They kept their word and declared war on Germany. While Germany invaded Poland in the west, Soviet troops moved into Poland from the east on September 17-18, 1939. Poland was divided between Germany and the Soviet Union by the Soviet-German Frontier and Friendship Treaty of 28 September 1939. Meanwhile, many other countries have also declared war on Germany, though these were symbolic declarations as even France and Britain were still busy preparing for war, while Poland was being destroyed.

6.2.1 The War Begins

Poland, as we have seen above, became the immediate cause of the War. On March 23, 1939 German troops had quietly occupied Memel (a German city under Lithuanian sovereignty) after Hitler had asked Lithuania to surrender it. On the same day, German Foreign Minister Ribbentrop called Polish Ambassador and dictated to him terms that Germany would like to impose upon Poland. He demanded that Danzig (which had already been Nazified) should be returned to Germany, and an east-west highway and rail-link across the Polish Corridor may be allowed so that East Prussia could be directly linked with Germany. This virtually meant a corridor across a corridor. Hitler, however, was calculating repeat of another Munich mistake by Britain which did not take place. Prime Minister Chamberlain announced unequivocally British guarantees to Poland. Later, when Italy invaded and annexed Albania (7th April), Britain gave similar guarantees to Greece and Rumania. France followed Britain in announcing

conscription. Hitler retaliated on the next day and repudiated the Polish-German non-aggression pact of 1934 and Anglo-German Naval Treaty of 1935.

The Anti-Comintern Pact was signed by Germany and Japan in November 1936 and, a year later, Italy too joined. Thus, the Rome-Berlin-Tokyo Axis represented three countries determination to liquidate world communism was formed. It was, in fact, an alliance against the Soviet Union. By August 1939 Hitler was prepared to settle the Polish issue on his terms; however, he was on the lookout for a plausible pretext. He got the arms of (an otherwise determined) Britain diplomatically twisted when Hitler agreed to have direct negotiations with Poland on Danzig issue. Hitler asked Britain, through its Ambassador in Berlin on August 29, 1939, to arrange a Polish delegation, to reach Berlin the next day, fully empowered to negotiate and conclude an agreement with the Germans. This was the most unusual demand. Normally, international negotiations take a lot of time to begin. In any case, formal proposals are first sent through diplomatic means before inviting foreign delegation, who could not arrive on August 30. Germany closed all doors for negotiation. This gave Hitler the much-awaited pretext for the planned invasion of Poland. The war broke out early in the morning of September 1, 1939, when German troops invaded Poland. England and France declared war on Germany on September 3, 1939. On 18 September the Soviet Union also invaded Poland, but neither Italy nor the United States entered the war for some time. Meanwhile, England and other allies were already in a war, yet attempts were still on for some solution. But Germany was determined for a full-fledged war.

6.2.2 USA and USSR Become Allies

When the war began, Germany and Italy were political allies, but Soviet-German non-aggression pact disappointed Mussolini. Italy did not enter the war till June 1940. Then, as France was on the verge of defeat and surrender, Italy joined the war on the side of Germany against France and the Allies. The Soviet Union did not join the war but was helping Germany by invading Poland. She later attacked Finland and was expelled from the membership of League of Nations. Stalin continued to trust Hitler until the Nazi dictator had defeated most European neighbours and attacked the Soviet Union on 22 June 1941. Meanwhile, Stalin had coerced three Baltic nations - Latvia, Lithuania and Estonia - to join the Soviet Union as its Union Republics. They lost their independence as Stalin told their leaders that if they refused to join USSR, they would be ruined by Germany.

The Soviet Union had also dictated terms to Rumania and recovered Bessarabia and Bukovina from it. Thus, by mid-1941 Soviet Union was busy collecting war gains without being in the war. Hitler had secured French surrender in June 1940. But Hitler was not so lucky where Spain was concerned. General Franco kept his country out of the war. Since it was being fought by Hitler in association with Stalin, Spain remained neutral throughout the war.

Public opinion in the United States was overwhelmingly opposed to being drawn into the war. In 1937, the US Congress had passed the Neutrality Act which also prohibited the sale of armaments in a future war. When the war broke out and Germany started bombing and destroying western democracies, Americans began weakening their neutrality stance. Cash and Carry Act was passed in November 1939, permitting countries at war to buy American weapons provided they paid

cash and carried them in their ships. When the war reached a crucial stage, the Lend-Lease Act was passed in March 1941. It allowed the President to sell, exchange, end the lease or otherwise dispose off any defence article. Thus, the US began supplying armaments to friendly countries such as Britain and China. Three months later when Soviet Union was attacked by Germany, she was also covered by the Lend-Lease Act.

The Soviet-German non-aggression pact signed in 1939 had been designed by Hitler to keep the Soviet Union in the dark about his actual intentions. As soon as Germany had defeated her enemies on the European continent, it began preparing for the invasion of the Soviet Union itself. But Stalin remained convinced that Hitler would not attack the Soviet Union. Everyone had warned Stalin of Nazi attack—Churchill, American Embassy and Stalin’s men in Tokyo. But Stalin refused to listen till 22 June 1941 when Germany launched the attack on the Soviet Union. Stalin was stunned at this and the Soviet Union sought Allied assistance. Britain accepted the Soviet Union into the Allied camp. In July, London and Moscow signed a military pact.

When the Soviet Union was facing a devastating war, the United States was forced to enter the war in December 1941, when Japan attacked its naval base in Pearl Harbour. American relations with Japan were never cordial. Japanese assets in America were already frozen. In August 1941 the United States had announced that any Japanese action against Thailand would cause her grave concern. Unsuccessful attempts were made for a meeting between US President Roosevelt and Japanese Prime Minister Kono in September. In October, Kono resigned and General Tojo became the Prime Minister of Japan. He openly encouraged conflict. In November, Britain had promised to declare war on Japan if the United States became involved in a war with that country. Tension was building up rapidly and war appeared imminent. On 6 December 1941 President Roosevelt made a personal request to the Japanese Emperor for help in maintaining peace. Instead, on December 7, 1941, Japan bombarded American Naval fleet based at Pearl Harbour (Hawaii Islands). A few hours later, Japan declared war “on the United States of America and the British Empire”. On December 11, both Germany and Italy declared war on the United States. The war thus became global.

Check Your Progress Exercise 1

Note: i) Use the space given below for your answer.

ii) See the end of the Unit for tips for your answer.

1) What was the immediate cause for the Second World War?

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- 2) Write a note on the concept of collective security.

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6.3 DEFEAT OF THE AXIS POWERS

6.3.1 Defeat of Italy and Germany

The two European Fascist Powers had conquered most of the countries on the continent. Britain was under constant attack, and large parts of the Soviet Union including the three Baltic Republics had been overrun by the Germans. In 1943 the Allied powers decided to launch an offensive against the Axis by liquidating Italian Empire in Africa. This objective was achieved by May 1943. The Italians were disturbed and Fascist structure gave signs of cracking. The Allies decided on “Operation Hugky” to start Italian invasion through Sicily. It was not an all-out effort because the idea was to use Italy as a base to be able to bomb Germany and the Balkans. In July 1943, following heavy air attacks, a large number of Italians surrendered in Sicily. Mussolini visited Hitler and asked for more German assistance, but was turned down. Mussolini summoned a meeting of Fascist Grand Council which asked the King to take direct command. On July 25, 1943, King Victor Emmanuel III dismissed Mussolini and appointed Marshal Badoglio to head the new government. Mussolini was arrested. Italy finally surrendered unconditionally on September 3, 1943. On the same day, however, Germans entered Rome and kept it under their occupation for several months. Allied forces could capture Rome only on June 4, 1944.

The Allied powers decided to defeat Germany by opening two fronts against her. From the east, the Soviet Union was pushing her out: in West England, America and its Allies launched an attack on Normandy to liberate France. By March 1944, the Axis forces were expelled from most of Ukraine and other parts of the Soviet Union. Soviet soil was cleared of German armies before the year ended. The West Front against Germany was opened on June 6, 1944. It began from the English Channel, and for this purpose, 150,000 American soldiers were transported every month.

Allied forces liberated France and entered Germany on September 11, 1944—ninety-seven days after their invasion. Immediately afterwards Hitler’s air force began a massive bombardment of London which continued till early 1945. As Germans began to be defeated, conspiracies were hatched to eliminate Hitler. The final assault on Germany was planned at the Yalta Conference in February 1945. All-round offensive was begun against Germany by the British, Canadian, French and the Americans forces. Meanwhile, the Soviet offensive was continuing unabated. The fighting was most fierce at the German Chancellery in whose underground defences Hitler had set up his last headquarters. When everything was lost, the Nazi dictator, who was once dreaming of ruling over the entire

world, committed suicide on April 30, 1945. Hitler had nominated Dönnitz as his successor but he could do nothing to save the country. On May 5, 1945, German commanders in northeast Germany, the Netherlands and Denmark surrendered unconditionally; Nazi forces in Austria surrendered the next day. Finally, on the May 7, Dönnitz Government (of Germany) surrendered unconditionally “all land, sea and air forces of the Reich”. The war in Europe was over on May 8, 1945.

6.3.2 Defeat of Japan

The Allies were fighting hard for victory against Japan in the Far East. Hence the main responsibility fell on the United States, who was assisted by Britain, China, the Netherlands, Australia and New Zealand. Allied invasion of Japan was organised with China as the base. US General Douglas MacArthur directed these operations. Two allied campaigns were launched in the autumn of 1944. The one under Lord Mountbatten was aimed at the reconquest of Burma. The other, under Gen. MacArthur, involved the liberation of the Philippine Islands. Both the missions were completed by June 1945. The Potsdam conference which was meeting to decide the future of defeated Germany and other related issues gave a call to Japan in July 1945 “to proclaim now the unconditional surrender of all Japanese armed forces”. The ultimatum was ignored by the Japanese who continued to fight. At this stage, America decided to use the atom bomb and secure Japan’s unconditional surrender. On August 6, 1945, the American Air Force dropped the first-ever atom bomb on the important Japanese City of Hiroshima and wiped out more than half of the target area. Two days later (August 8), the Soviet Union declared war on Japan and began an offensive in Manchuria and Southern Sakhalin (both were then under Japanese control). Progress of the Soviet troops was swift. On August 9, 1945, a second atom bomb was dropped on Nagasaki, unleashing unprecedented destruction. The next day, Japan sued for peace. Fighting stopped but surrender documents were signed only on September 2, 1945, onboard the US battleship *Missouri*. The Second World War finally ended with Japan coming under the American occupation.

The consequence of war was the total defeat of three Axis powers and the victory of the Allies. This also meant the victory of democracy and the defeat of Fascism and dictatorship.

6.4 PEACEMAKING AFTER SECOND WORLD WAR

The conclusion of peace treaties after the Second World War proved to be a very difficult task. After two years of termination of hostilities, treaties were concluded only with five of the defeated powers. They were Italy, Rumania, Bulgaria, Hungary and Finland. The Treaty of peace with Austria could be concluded only in 1955 and with Japan in 1952. Germany could not be reunited. It remained divided between pro-west Federal Republic of Germany (West Germany) and the Democratic German Republic under the influence of the Soviet Union. Since Germany was not reunited, no treaty with Germany as such was ever concluded. Two Germanys were finally united in 1990 into one Germany. We shall briefly deal with the Potsdam Conference and then the peace treaties concluded with other defeated powers.

6.4.1 The Potsdam Conference

The Potsdam (Berlin) Conference was held during July-August 1945. Germany had unconditionally surrendered to the Allies. Several decisions had been taken during different wartime conferences regarding the future of Germany and the East European countries. A formal arrangement had now to be made in the light of these decisions. The Potsdam Conference was attended by Joseph Stalin, Winston Churchill, Chiang Kai-Shek and the US President Harry Truman. They were assisted by high powered delegations. The Conference took important decisions regarding the future set up in Germany pending the conclusion of a formal treaty of peace. Preparations were also begun for the signing of peace treaties to be concluded with other defeated powers. Japan was yet to be defeated. Pending the final demarcation of the western borders of Poland, south-eastern Prussia and the areas to the east of rivers Oder and Neisse would constitute the western parts of Poland. It was also agreed that as soon as possible, free and fair democratic elections would be held in Poland. Potsdam Conference decided the Allied forces would be immediately withdrawn from Iran and Tangier was to be declared an international area. No reparation was to be taken from Austria.

The conference took decisions regarding the basis of surrender by Japan. Imperialistic elements would be eliminated and Japan would be disarmed. The war criminals of Japan would be punished. Immediately after her surrender, Allied military control would be established in Japan and eventually a democratic government would be set up. The sovereignty of Japan would be limited to her four major and a few smaller Islands. All foreign territories occupied by Japan before or during the Second World War would be liberated and transferred to the countries where they lawfully belonged.

The conditions as spelt out at the Potsdam Conference for the Japanese surrender were not accepted by Japan. The United States of America, without taking the Soviet Union into confidence, dropped atom bombs on two of the Japanese cities early in August 1945 compelling her to surrender unconditionally on August 10, 1945. Thus, the Second World War came to an end. The fact is that the United States developed and used atom bomb without the knowledge of the Soviet Union became one of the causes that gave birth to the Cold War immediately after the Second World War.

6.4.2 Treaties of Peace

The victorious powers had learned but not much from their experiences with the peace treaties concluded after the First World War. Peace treaties concluded after the end of Second World War once again brought territorial divisions and adjustments among European states; occupation of territories and overseas colonies of the vanquished and imposition of reparations.

Unlike the Paris Peace Conference of 1919, only a Foreign Ministers meeting took place in London from September 11 to October 3, 1945. By that time serious differences had developed between the Western powers on the one hand and the Soviet Union on the other. Very little progress could be made in the London Conference, nor could any progress be achieved in the subsequent three meetings. The draft-treaties were prepared in these meetings, to be concluded with five powers—Italy, Rumania, Bulgaria, Hungary and Finland. Thereafter, the Paris Conference was held from July 29 to October 15, 1946. This was followed by

the other meetings of the Foreign Ministers Committee and the treaties were finally approved by the Committee at New York on December 12, 1946. Finally, these treaties were signed by the Allies on the one side and the five above mentioned defeated powers on the other. Separate treaties were concluded with each of them.

The main provisions of these peace treaties may be briefly mentioned here. (i) The Treaty concluded with Italy deprived her of several territories. France, Greece and Yugoslavia gained territories at the cost of Italy. (ii) Trieste became an independent Port under the charge of a Governor appointed by the Security Council of the United Nations. (iii) Albania and Ethiopia regained their Independence and became sovereign states. (iv) Italy was considerably reduced and she was required to pay a big amount of money as reparation within seven years. (v) The Romania Treaty provided for the transfer of the provinces of Bessarabia, and Bukovina from Romania to the Soviet Union and Dobruja to Bulgaria. She was to pay reparation to the Soviet Union and limits were imposed on the strength of its military forces. (vi) Hungary was made to return to Czechoslovakia some of the villages situated to the south of River Danube which she had occupied in 1938. (vii) The Province of Transylvania was returned by Hungary to Romania. She was also required to pay reparation and was disarmed. Bulgaria did not lose any territory. It gained the territory of Dobruja from Romania. But like others, Bulgaria was asked to pay reparation and her armed forces were curtailed. (viii) Finland was deprived of several small territories which all went to the Soviet Union. The area Salla, the province of Petsamo and the Naval Base of Porkkala Udd were given by her to the Soviet Union. Like other defeated powers, reparation was imposed upon Finland also. Its armed forces were considerably curtailed and limited. These Five treaties gave a maximum advantage to the Soviet Union. Another country which gained sufficient territory, power and prestige was Yugoslavia which became the most powerful nation in the Balkans and a rival of Italy.

Austria: Austria had been occupied by the German army in 1938 and ever since continued as an occupied part of defeated Germany. Austria was treated as a “liberated territory”. The Moscow Conference of 1943 pledged to create a sovereign state of Austria. But, soon after the war, serious differences developed among the Allies. The Soviet Union wanted to impose severe economic restrictions on Austria. This was not acceptable to the Western powers. The deadlock remained for nearly 10 years. Finally, Austria agreed to declare itself a “neutral” country and to pay some compensation to the Soviet Union. Thereupon, the Soviet Union agreed to separate the Austrian question from the problem of Germany. A Peace Treaty was signed by Austria on May 15, 1955, whereby it became a “neutral” country.

Japan: The Cold War and differences between the United States and the Soviet Union delayed the conclusion of the peace treaty with Japan. But, unlike Germany and Austria, Japan was under the occupation of only the American forces. After the Japanese surrender on August 10, 1945, an interim military administration had been set up by the Americans. The entire authority was vested in the hands of the Supreme Commander of the Allied Powers. General MacArthur was appointed as the Supreme Commander and Japanese Administrator. A meeting to draw up a peace Treaty was convened by the United States at San Francisco in 1951. The meeting was attended by 52 countries. It was attended by the Soviet

Union and other socialist countries, but India and Burma refused to attend it. Some of the proposed terms of peace were not acceptable to India. Even the Soviet Union found it impossible to sign the draft treaty. The treaty drafted under US influence was signed with Japan by 49 countries, on April 28, 1952. A separate peace treaty was signed by India with Japan in June 1952.

The Peace Treaty signed by Japan with the United States and 48 other countries had 27 articles. It recognised the independence of Korea. It may be remembered that Korea had been divided after the war between North Korea (Communist) and South Korea (Liberal Democracy). Japan surrendered its rights over the Islands of Formosa, Sakhalin and Kurile. The Islands of Bonin and Ryukyu (Okinawa) were placed under the American Trusteeship. The Japanese sovereignty was limited to her four principal and a few small Islands. Secondly, Japan agreed to give up all her rights to China. Thirdly, Japan accepted responsibility for the war and liability to pay reparation but given economic conditions, it was exempted from the payment of reparation. This was done because the Treaty was concluded much after the heat of the war had subsided and because it was now a close ally of the United States. Lastly, it was agreed in principle that the foreign armed forces would be withdrawn from Japan.

Germany: Germany was divided into four occupation zones immediately after its surrender. The western powers alleged that, in violation of the understanding earlier reached, Soviet Union was converting its zone of Eastern Germany into a communist state. This hampered not only the unification of Germany but also the conclusion of a peace treaty. Nevertheless, both the Soviet Union and the Western powers took several unilateral decisions regarding Germany. The first such decision was taken by Britain and the United States who merged their zones into one on January 1, 1947. Later, France also allowed the merger of her zone with the unified western zone. Subsequently, the three powers decided to set up a free, independent and democratic government in West Germany. The Federal Republic of Germany (FRG), comprising erstwhile western zones, was formally established on September 21, 1949. The Western powers formally terminated the 'state of war' with the Federal Republic of Germany in 1951.

Soon after the setting up of the Federal Republic of Germany, the Soviet Union proceeded to create an independent state of East Germany. It was designated as the German Democratic Republic (GDR) and was organised on the Socialist pattern of the USSR. Full sovereignty was granted to GDR by the Soviet Union by a treaty concluded between them in September 1955—one year after the sovereignty of West Germany was recognised by the Western powers. Thus, Germany remained divided into two hostile countries till 1990—one was aligned with the West had capitalist order and had made very rapid industrial progress, and the other was aligned to the Soviet Union and had her economy based on socialism and her political system patterned on the Soviet Union. The two Germany—West Germany and East Germany began the process of unification in 1989. United Germany was born only in October 1990.

6.5 INDIA'S CONTRIBUTION IN THE SECOND WORLD WAR

India's contribution to the British Empire during the Second World War has for long been overlooked. It is only over recent years that the sacrifices made by

India are being acknowledged. As in the First World War, Indian soldiers were called upon by Britain to help in the war effort. The size of the British Indian army at its peak reached 2.5 million – making it the largest volunteer army in the world. Approximately 89,000 Indian soldiers died fighting for the Empire.

Indian soldiers fought in all the major battles – Tobruk, Monte Cassino, Kohima and Imphal. They fought on all major fronts – East and North Africa, Italy, Burma, Singapore, Malay Peninsula, Guam and Indo China – and secured South East Asia from the Japanese. Some 700,000 Indian soldiers fought in the Burma and South-East Asian theatre. Historians have begun to record only now: among the fiercest of the battles during the war was the Battle of Kohima and Imphal in 1944. The Japanese 15th Army, 85,000 strong for the invasion of India, was essentially destroyed, with 53,000 dead and missing in the Battle of Kohima and Imphal.

The entire Indian subcontinent stood transformed during the war years. The subcontinent became a vast supply ground for the war against the Japanese in South East Asia. Millions of Indians toiled for the Empire under pathetic conditions. Thousands of Indians mined coal in Bihar, built supply roads from India into Myanmar and China, including the famous Ledo Road between China and India in North East India. In addition to meeting its requirements, India became a major supplier of war material to the Allies. Hundreds of its new factories maintained regular supplies of textile and other war-related material to all the Allied countries. Official figures suggest that thousands of Indians working at ports and factories died from Japanese aerial bombings on India's eastern coastline.

Thousands of non-combatants were sent overseas to man and manage the supply lines and support services. These were the 'coolies' who loaded and unloaded cargo at imperial ports or cleared lands for aerodromes. Merchant seamen living around the ports of London, Cardiff, Liverpool and South Shields worked to ensure that the supply lines to Britain remained open. They worked under atrocious conditions for less pay than their white counterparts.

The war-related British taxes and levies further imposed a crushing burden on India's poverty-stricken population. Indians not only fought in the war but also financed it. The noted military historian Srinath Raghavan writes that by 1942-43, India was paying more than Britain towards the war, transforming its relationship with Britain from a debtor to a creditor - with Britain owing it a mind-boggling £1.3 billion by the end of the war (*India's War: The Making of Modern South Asia 1939-1945*)

The Second World War had a huge impact on India. It greatly energized India's freedom movement. Millions participated in the Quit India movement of 1942. Netaji Subhas Chandra Bose raised the Indian National Army (INA), consisting of Indian soldiers and prisoners of war (POWs) of Japanese in South East Asia, to fight and overthrow the British rule in India. Netaji sought Japanese help for his mission. The INA and Japanese forces advanced but were stopped by the British Army in Imphal and Kohima in the North East. There were other outcomes of the war. The Second World War produced a professional and highly regarded Indian armed forces. Hundreds of new factories that were set up to produce and supply war material laid the foundation of India's manufacturing sector. Many in the business circle made huge profits and became industrial entrepreneurs

after independence. The war also made it clear to the great powers after the war that India was the pivot of the Asian security. Arguing in 1946 for a permanent seat on the UN Security Council, Jawaharlal Nehru noted: “It is India that counts in the defence and security of these regions far more than any other country.”

6.6 EMERGENCE OF SUPERPOWERS

The concept of Super Power developed only after the Second World War when some of the erstwhile big powers were overtaken in respect of power (capability) to influence the minds and actions of other states) by two countries, namely the United States of America and the Union of Soviet Socialist Republic (USSR, commonly known as the Soviet Union). On the eve of the Second World War, British Empire, France, Italy and Japan were among the recognised big powers. When the war ended not only Germany but Italy and Japan were also defeated. The defeated countries became militarily weak, politically insignificant and economically impoverished. Among victors, Britain had become so weak that by 1947 it was unable to maintain its troops even in Greece and Turkey for their defence against communism. British Empire could not be sustained. Once India became independent in 1947, the process of decolonization was accelerated. Britain was still recognised as a big power and occupied a permanent seat in the newly-constituted UN Security Council, but its strength had considerably diminished. France had been a victim of German occupation until a second front was opened and it was liberated in August 1944. Although France emerged victorious and was given a permanent seat in the Security Council, yet for several years after the war, it was far from being a powerful nation. That left only two of the principal vectors i.e. the United States and the Soviet Union who gained in military power and political status. Thus, an important consequence of the Second World War was the emergence of these two victors as Super Powers. Even after Britain, France and China became nuclear powers they could not challenge the Super Power status of US and USSR.

6.6.1 The United States Became a Nuclear Power

Towards the end of the war, there was just one country which possessed the potential that no other state had. In July 1945, the Americans exploded, experimentally, the first nuclear device in the history of mankind. In August, they dropped two atom bombs at Hiroshima and Nagasaki which broke the resistance of Japan and brought about her unconditional surrender. The world was shocked, and the Soviet Union was disgusted because even when the two were allies in the war, the United States did not indicate the fact that she was developing an atom bomb. Even when the US decided to use the atom bomb in Japan, the other Allies were kept in the dark till the actual use of it.

Besides its nuclear weapons, what had helped America become a Super Power was the fact that no battle ever took place on her territory throughout war. After the Pearl Harbour, Americans were engaged in an unprecedented war, but the civilian lives and property were left untouched. This gave an added advantage to the Americans because their other Allies in the war had suffered heavy civilian losses also. Britain was heavily bombarded; France was under occupation for four years and the Soviet Union had been a target of German invasion till the second front was opened against her.

6.6.2 Soviet Union's Challenge to the United States

The power base of the Soviet Union was not comparable to that of the United States. The USSR had succeeded in establishing communist regimes in Poland and several other East European countries, which were liberated by its army from the Nazi control. But it did not possess nuclear weapons until testing of first such device in 1949. The USSR had suffered enormous losses during the war. Not only its troops were killed and wounded in large numbers but it had suffered civilian losses also and the destruction of industrial and physical infrastructure.

The Soviet Union became a nuclear power in 1949 although until 1953 the US maintained clear superiority in areas like delivery system. But, once the USSR became a nuclear weapon state, it also began developing the delivery system such as aircraft and missiles. It was because of its rising military capability, achievements in the space and other sciences and its attraction as an alternative socialist model of economic development and social justice that her status improved and she was recognised as a Super Power.

Immediately after the Second World War, the Soviet Union had made an all-out effort to overtake the United States in science and technology. It subordinated everything including post-war reconstruction to catching up with the Americans in military technology. Once the Soviet Union developed its nuclear power, it became a rival of the United States and the two came to be recognised as the Super Powers. Both led a power bloc each. After the Second World War, the United States and the Soviet Union faced each other directly but often through their proxy regimes and allies in different parts of the world. According to Lundestad, "They were the two main actors in the international area; the geographic distance separating them was gone, but the political distance would soon be greater than it had ever been".

Check Your Progress Exercise 2

Note: i) Use the space given below for your answer.

ii) See the end of the Unit for tips for your answer.

1) How did the Second World War impact India?

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6.7 LET US SUM UP

World War II broke out when Nazi Germany invaded Poland on 1st September 1939. Two days later, England and France declared war on Germany. Earlier two arch rivals, Germany and the Soviet Union had concluded a non-aggression pact. Major causes of the Second World War were the humiliating terms imposed on Germany by the Treaty of Versailles; failure of the collective security system

and disarmament which was thought to be a sure guarantee of avoiding war; the world economic crisis which encouraged military and aggressive actions in countries like Japan; the creation of Rome-Berlin-Tokyo Axis, an alliance of three fascist powers determined to destroy existing world order; the problem of dissatisfaction of minorities; the policy of appeasement pursued by Britain and supported by France to win over the Fascist and Nazi dictators: and finally German attack on Poland that became the immediate cause of the war.

To begin with, several countries joined the war on the side of Britain and her allies, but America kept out of it till outstanding disputes led Japan to attack Pearl harbour which forced the United States entry into War as an Ally in December 1941. The Soviet Union had invaded Poland and Finland and was expelled from League of Nations. But, ignoring the Non-Aggression Pact, Germany attacked the Soviet Union in June 1941. The Soviet Union immediately aligned itself with Britain. Meanwhile, Italy had entered the War in June 1940 by declaring War on France and siding with Germany. The Axis powers suffered their first setback when Italy was attacked in 1943. Mussolini was dismissed by the king and later Italy surrendered unconditionally, although for some time Rome was occupied by Germans. After a second front was opened by UK and USA, Germany not only lost France but was forced to surrender in May 1945. Japan continued to fight in the Pacific till two atom bombs were dropped by American in August 1945 forcing Japan to surrender. Thus, the War ended with the defeat of the three fascist powers; and the victory of the Allies.

Peace-making efforts after the war proved to be a very difficult task. The Allies had convened the Potsdam Conference (1945) for drawing up a peace treaty with Germany. No peace treaty could be concluded with any of the defeated countries immediately after the war. But after prolonged diplomatic activities, peace treaties were concluded with Italy, Romania, Hungary and Finland; and later with Austria and Japan. Germany remained occupied for several years and naturally, no peace treaty could be concluded for several years.

The most significant outcome of the war was the partition of Germany into four occupation zones. Later three Western Zones became one sovereign country, and in the east, a Soviet-backed government was established. As east European countries were liberated by the Soviet army, they were given communist governments. The Cold War began between two power blocs into which the world war divided.

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6.9 ANSWERS TO CHECK YOUR PROGRESS EXERCISES

Check Your Progress Exercise 1

- 1) The immediate cause of the war was the German invasion of Poland in September 1939 which led to a military response from England and France.
- 2) The principle of collective security that was written into the covenant of the League of Nations called for providing security to a victim of international aggression. Members of the League would take collective action against the aggressor in the form of economic sanctions, or military support to the victim of aggression or both.

Check Your Progress Exercise 2

- 1) Your answer should include the following: i) The War energised Indian freedom movement -with millions taking part in Quit India movement on the one hand and Netaji Bose raising the Indian National Army to overthrow the British rule. ii) Manufacturing industry got a boost as it had to meet the war supplies. iii) India also financed the war, emerging as a creditor nation at the end of the war. iv) The war also made the great powers realise that India was the pivot of Asian security